

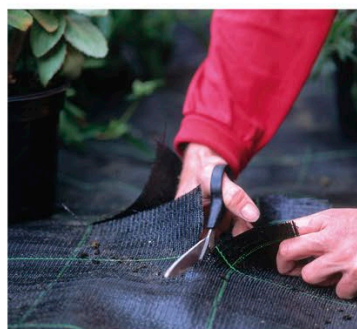
PLANTING A GRAVEL OR SCREE GARDEN

Gravel gardens are ideal for alpine and rock plants. Stones can be worked into a scheme to create a rock garden, or a variety of rock and stone sizes used on a slope to form a natural scree. A gravel or slate chip mulch helps

keep the plant leaves and stems dry, and prevents rotting, but lay weed-suppressing fabric over the ground first. This excludes light and stops weed seeds from germinating, but still allows moisture through to the plant.



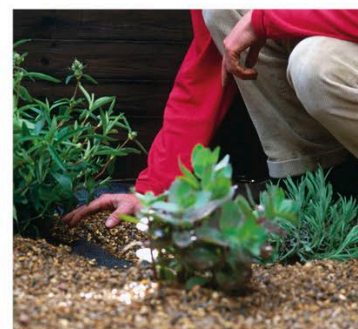
A weed-free gravel garden



1 Lay the fabric
Measure your bed, and buy sufficient weed-suppressing fabric to cover it. Overlap the edges when joining two pieces together. Cut crosses where you plan to plant.



2 Plant up
Fold back the flaps, and dig a hole, putting the excavated soil on a plastic sheet. Insert the plant, water in, and backfill with soil. Firm in and replace the flaps around the plant stems.



3 Add gravel mulch
Trim the fabric around the stems and continue to plant in this way. When the bed is planted, spread a 2–3in (5–8cm) layer of gravel over the fabric and around each plant.

at the feet of slightly taller, feathery-leaved pulsatillas or the airy *Linum narbonense*. As well as shape and form, use contrasting textures. You could include the almost bead-like foliage of certain hylotelephiums and sedums, spiky houseleek (*Sempervivum*) rosettes, and the pointy-tipped gray leaves of *Euphorbia myrsinites*, which would make eye-catching partners for the white-haired leaves of edelweiss (*Leontopodium*) or the silky, silver leaves of celmisias.

Most alpine plants like an open, sunny site and will not thrive if shaded by overhanging trees or neighboring plants. Plant them with space to spread and use a dry mulch, such as gravel, to keep the stems and leaves dry at all times. Mulches also act as a foil for the plants.

If you have limited space, plant a selection of alpine plants in small pots filled with gritty potting mix. Many plants in this group are drought-tolerant and thrive in containers, and when grouped together make colorful displays. Troughs can be given a modern makeover by planting alpine plants between slate chips (see box right), or using a ground glass or shell mulch.

Raised beds offer another design option for those with small gardens. They are also useful for people with reduced mobility, allowing them to access the plants more easily. Use raised beds to create miniature landscapes with plants spreading between rocks and pebbles. Dry stone walls offer ideal sites for many crevice-lovers, such as aubretias and sedums, while cascading alpine plants, such as *Saxifraga* ‘Tumbling Waters’, are perfect for the tops of walls.

Year-round interest

Many alpine plants flower in spring and early summer, just after the snow melts and before the heat of midsummer in their natural habitat. For color earlier in the year, plant spring bulbs, such as alpine narcissus or crocuses, among evergreen perennials, conifers, and small shrubs. The choice of flowers at the peak flowering times is vast, so coordinate your color

schemes for a dramatic performance. Hot colors, such as the bright yellow sedums and wallflowers (*Erysimum*) and scarlet and orange helianthemums, create highlights against more subdued blues and purples. As the summer progresses, select later-flowering rock plants, including phlox, crepis, and diascias, followed by the pink *Silene schafta*, gentians, and berry-bearing gaultherias in the fall.

PLANTING A SLATE-FILLED TROUGH

Topped with slate chips, this decorative trough mirrors a natural mountain scree, and provides a long season of color in spring and summer. Plants included in this display are *Draba* species, erigerons, saxifrages, *Silene acaulis*, and *Townsendia grandiflora*. However, any small alpine plants that have different leaf textures and flower colors will work equally well. Move your trough to its final position before you start, as it will be very heavy once planted.



1 Prepare the trough
Cover the drainage holes at the base of the trough with crocks. Add a 2in (5cm) layer of gravel. Fill up the trough with equal parts of soil-based potting mix and sand, to 2in (5cm) from the top.

2 Add slates and plants
Push the slate chips vertically into the soil, leaving spaces for the alpine plants. Water the plants, and plant them into the gaps, making sure the roots are covered with the sand and potting mix blend. Water well.